

João Franco

Updated August 19, 2026

PERSONAL DETAILS	Ph.D. student in Complex Systems and Data Science Vermont Complex Systems Institute University of Vermont Burlington, Vermont, USA <i>E-mail:</i> joao.franco@uvm.edu <i>Websites:</i> https://okfranco.github.io/ , LinkedIn and Google Scholar profile	
RESEARCH INTERESTS	Complex Systems, Computational Social Science, Belief Dynamics	
EDUCATION	The University of Vermont , Burlington, Vermont, USA Ph.D. in Complex Systems and Data Science (GPA: 4.0/4.0) <i>Advisors:</i> Laurent Hébert-Dufresne and Juniper L. Lovato Nova School of Business and Economics (Nova SBE) , Lisbon, Portugal M.Sc. in Finance, Specialization in Data and Business Analytics (GPA: top 1.1%) <i>Advisor:</i> Joana Gonçalves de Sá B.Sc. in Management (GPA: top 3%)	2025–Present 2015–2020
PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE (RESEARCH)	Vermont Complex Systems Institute , Burlington, Vermont, USA Graduate Research Assistant Social Physics and Complexity Lab , Lisbon, Portugal Technical Consultant Copenhagen Business School , (Remote) Research Assistant (Part-time)	2025–Present 2025 2022–2023
FUNDING & AWARDS	Fulbright Grant for Ph.D. with FCT¹ support , Fulbright Portugal, Role: Awardee. (\$22.000) Nova Fellowship for Excellence , Nova SBE, Role: Awardee. (80% of M.Sc. tuition fees) Nova Excelência Scholarship , Nova SBE, Role: Awardee, (1 st year B.Sc. tuition fees)	2025 2018 2015
PUBLICATIONS	Preprints, in reverse chronological order: 2. I. Damião, P. Almeida, J. Franco , N. Santos, P. Magalhães, J. Gonçalves-Sá (2026); <i>Evidence of political bias in search engines and language models before major elections</i> ; arXiv.org 1. J. Franco [†] , I. Damião [†] , M. Silva, P. Almeida, P. Magalhães, J. Gonçalves-Sá (2026); <i>Cross-National Evidence of Disproportionate Media Visibility for the Radical Right in the 2024 European Elections</i> ; arXiv.org [†] These authors contributed equally to this work.	
TALKS & POSTERS	Bridging Simple and Complex Contagions in Belief Dynamics: A Voter Model Extension , Poster, NetSci 2026, Boston, MA, USA Bridging Simple and Complex Contagions in Belief Dynamics: A Voter Model Extension , Talk, NEERCS 2026, Rochester, NY, USA Evaluating Political Salience Using Topic Modeling Approaches , Poster, CompleNet 2024, Exeter, UK	2026 2026 2024
TEACHING	Strategy (B.Sc.) , Teaching Assistant, Nova SBE [in-person] Introduction to Programming in Python (B.Sc.) , Teaching Assistant, Nova SBE [in-person] Calculus I (B.Sc.) , Teaching Assistant, Nova SBE [in-person]	2019 2019 2018

¹Portugal's Foundation for Science and Technology

ORGANIZATION OF CONFERENCES	IC2S2 ² , Session Chair (Human-AI Interaction and Practice, 2) & Volunteer, Burlington, VT, USA	2026
PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE	Social Data Lab , Lisbon, Portugal Data Analyst	2022–2024
(OTHER)	The Boston Consulting Group , Lisbon, Portugal & Stockholm, Sweden Strategy Consultant	2018, 2020–2022
VARIA	Technical: Python, SQL, LaTeX, Power BI, Looker Studio, SQL Server Products, Google Cloud Platform, Airflow Languages: Portuguese (Native), English (Proficient), French (Basic) Additional: Strategic planning, large-scale transformation initiatives, budgeting and financial forecasting, stakeholder management.	

²International Conference on Computational Social Science